Lahore and ‘became somewhat deranged and fell into great grief ’. By the time they reached Rohtas in February 1590, the party was thoroughly demoralized. Moreover, as it was the rainy season, Hamida Banu suggested that they rest awhile within the fort but her son, so long used to bending even the elements to his will, refused, saying that ‘honour did not allow that he should be in comfort and the world in trouble’. Nor could Akbar allow his amirs and soldiery to see any weakness in him. Instead, he organized a qumargha hunt, as he had done so many times in the past, where no fear or uncertainty would be tolerated. A few days later, after crossing the Jhelum, Akbar was thrown off an elephant while trying to subdue a mast animal and, for a while, to the terror of his amirs, remained unconscious. Indeed, Akbar’s condition was so critical that there were sporadic acts of plunder in the area, as the Padshah was believed dead. When he regained consciousness, he was bled in the arm and then continued his journey by elephant litter. Finally, in March 1590, after an absence of more than ten months, Akbar rode back into Lahore.

The city that Akbar returned to would have appeared sadly altered over the year. Two of his great statesmen had died in addition to his favourite musician, and Akbar would have felt bereft. A Brajbhasha lyric is popularly attributed to Akbar in Rajasthani legend which might very well have reflected his feelings at this stage in his life:

> Peethal so majlis gayee, Tansen so raga,
> Hansibo-ramibo-bolibo, gayo Birbal saath
>
> (With the death of Peethal have gone the pleasures of themajlis, with Tansen music itself has fled
> With the passing of Birbal have gone laughter, good companyand conversation.)

Hamida Banu, Gulbadan, and the other ladies in the entourage returned to Fatehpur Sikri in October of 1590, despairing of Akbar’s ever coming back to the city. Abu’l Fazl admits that at this stage, Hamida Banu had thought that Akbar would return to the capital. This belies the belief that Fatehpur Sikri was ever ‘abandoned’ by Akbar due to some sudden, unexpected catastrophe. It was, rather, his continued stay at Lahore which was inexplicable.

Meanwhile, Kuar Man Singh, who had been serving as Subedar of Bihar since 1587, learning of the death of his father now made the journey